

LOGO
PLACEHOLDER

A FREE RESOURCE
FOR WICHITA BUYERS

THE FIRST-TIME

Homebuyer *Resource* Guide

Everything I wish someone had handed me before my first closing.

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HEADSHOT
PLACEHOLDER

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BEFORE WE BEGIN

Hey — read this first.

If you're reading this, you're probably somewhere between "I think I want to buy a house" and "I have absolutely no idea where to start." That's a normal place to be. Almost everybody who's ever bought a home stood exactly where you're standing right now, googling things at 11 p.m. and feeling a little out of their depth.

Here's the truth nobody says out loud: buying your first home feels overwhelming because it **is** a lot. It's likely the biggest check you've ever written, wrapped in paperwork written by people who get paid by the word, surrounded by advice from everyone who's ever owned a home and a few people who haven't. Of course it feels like a lot. The feeling isn't a sign you're not ready. It's a sign you're paying attention.

A little about me. Before real estate, I spent years as a diesel mechanic, welder, and fabricator — I built things, fixed things, and learned the hard way what's worth worrying about and what isn't. I'm an Army veteran. I've moved my own life across the country with everything I owned in a truck. And these days I help people in and around Wichita find a place to land. I've seen the parts of this process that go smooth and the parts that go sideways, and I got tired of watching good people get blindsided by stuff a five-minute conversation could've prevented.

So I made this. Not a brochure. Not a sales pitch dressed up as "value." An actual guide — the one I wish someone had handed me — that walks you through the whole thing in plain English, with the local stuff that only matters if you're buying *here*, in Wichita.

My commitment to you is simple: I'd rather you make a great decision than a fast one. Read this. Mark it up. Bring your questions. Whether you buy next month or next year, whether you use me or not, you'll walk away knowing how this actually works.

Let's get into it.

THE GUIDE

What's inside

01	Understanding the Homebuying Process	The 9 steps, start to keys
02	The Real Cost of Buying a Home	Every dollar, with Wichita numbers
03	Mortgages Made Simple	Loan types & the words that scare people
04	The Wichita Neighborhood Guide	8 areas, honestly compared
05	My Personal Home Tour Checklist	Print it. Bring it to showings.
06	Things Nobody Tells First-Time Buyers	The stuff between the lines
07	Local Resources I Trust	Your team, in one place
08	Exclusive Buyer Perks	Things I've lined up for you
09	Moving Day Survival Guide	From boxes to first night
—	Why Work With Garrett	How I actually do this
★	The Wichita Homebuyer Game Plan	Your next move

Read it, mark it up, bring your questions. That's the whole point.

Section 01

Understanding the homebuying process

Nine steps. That's it. It feels like a hundred because they happen fast and the words are unfamiliar — but the path is the same for almost everyone. Here's exactly what happens, where people trip, and what I'd whisper to you if I were standing next to you.

1

Get pre-approved

Before you fall in love with anything, you talk to a lender. They look at your income, debts, and credit, and tell you what you can actually borrow. A pre-approval letter is what makes a seller take you seriously.

MISTAKE Touring homes before you've talked to a lender — then falling for a place you can't get financed.

INSIDER The number they approve you for is the ceiling, not the goal. We'll talk about why on page 18.

2

Build your home search

Now we get specific: budget, must-haves, deal-breakers, and which parts of town actually fit your life. I set you up with real-time listings so you're not refreshing a public app that's three days behind.

MISTAKE Confusing "wants" with "needs." A finished basement is a want. A 20-minute commute might be a need.

INSIDER Pick your top three neighborhoods early. It keeps the search focused and the disappointment low.

3

Tour homes

The fun part. We walk through homes in person — and I'm the guy noticing the soft spot in the floor and the water heater that's on borrowed time while you're picturing your couch.

MISTAKE Touring ten houses in one day. You'll blur them together and start ignoring red flags.

INSIDER Use my checklist on page 14. A mechanic's eye on a house saves real money later.

4

Write an offer

Found it? We put together an offer — price, closing date, what we're asking the seller to cover, and the contingencies that protect you. This is where having someone in your corner who negotiates for a living actually pays for itself.

MISTAKE Leading with a lowball "to test them" in a home you love. You can talk yourself right out of the house.

INSIDER Terms can matter as much as price. The right closing date or a repair credit can beat a few thousand dollars.

5

Inspection period

Once the offer's accepted, you hire an inspector to crawl the house top to bottom. You get a report, and a window to ask for repairs, a credit, or — if it's bad enough — to walk away.

MISTAKE Skipping the inspection to "win" in a hot market. That's how you inherit a \$9,000 surprise.

INSIDER No house is perfect. We're hunting for the expensive stuff — roof, foundation, systems — not chipped paint.

6

Appraisal

Your lender sends an appraiser to confirm the home is worth what you're paying. They protect the bank's money — and, by extension, yours.

MISTAKE Assuming a low appraisal kills the deal. It doesn't have to — there are several ways to handle a gap.

INSIDER This is a normal step, not a verdict on your taste. Let me handle it if the number comes in light.

WHERE YOU ARE

Steps 1–4 are the "deciding" half. Steps 5–9 are the "protecting and finishing" half. By here, you've already done the hard part: knowing what you want and going after it.

7

Final loan approval

Behind the scenes, your lender is finishing underwriting — verifying everything one last time. Your only job here is to be boring: don't change anything about your money.

MISTAKE

Financing a truck or opening a credit card before closing. It can sink the loan days before the finish line.

INSIDER

Respond to your lender fast. The deals that slow down are usually waiting on a document, not a decision.

8

Closing day

You sit down at the title company, sign a stack of papers, and the home becomes yours. There's a final walkthrough first to make sure it's in the shape you agreed to.

MISTAKE

Wiring money based on an email you didn't verify by phone. Wire fraud is real — we confirm details out loud.

INSIDER

Bring a valid ID and your hand might cramp from signing. That's the worst of it. I'll be right there.

9

Move in

Keys in hand. Change the locks, set up utilities, and stand in your empty living room for a second — you earned it. Section 9 has your moving playbook.

INSIDER

Take photos the day you move in, before furniture. Great for insurance and for the "remember when" later.

THE WHOLE THING

From pre-approval to keys, a smooth purchase usually runs **30–45 days once you're under contract**. It's a sprint with a few waiting rooms — and you don't run it alone.

Section 02

The real cost of buying a home

The sticker price is the part everyone talks about. It's the costs *around* it that blindsides people. Let's lay all of them on the table so nothing surprises you at the worst possible moment.

The money buckets

COST	WHAT IT IS	BALLPARK
Down payment	Your stake in the home, paid up front	0–20%
Earnest money	A "good faith" deposit that shows you're serious (it counts toward your costs)	~1%
Closing costs	Lender, title, and county fees to finalize	2–5%
Inspection	Your independent check of the house	\$350–\$550
Appraisal	Lender's value check (often rolled into closing)	\$500–\$700
Moving	Truck, movers, supplies	\$300–\$2,000
Utility setup	Deposits and connection fees	\$100–\$400
Repair fund	The cushion for the thing that breaks month one	\$1,000+

A WICHITA REALITY CHECK

Wichita is one of the more affordable mid-size markets in the country, which is great news for a first purchase. These figures are ballparks to plan around — for today's real numbers on a specific home, text me and I'll run them with you.

A REAL EXAMPLE

The \$250,000 Wichita home

Let's make it concrete. Say you're buying a \$250,000 home — a very normal first-home price around here. Here's roughly what you'd need on hand, depending on your loan.

3% DOWN
(CONVENTIONAL)

\$7,500

Lowest down for a standard loan. Plus closing & cash reserves.

3.5% DOWN (FHA)

\$8,750

First-timer favorite. Flexible credit requirements.

0% DOWN (VA / USDA)

\$0

No down payment if you qualify. We'll cover who does.

Cash to close, roughly (3.5% FHA example)

Down payment		\$8,750
Closing costs (~3%)		\$7,500
Earnest money*		\$2,500
Inspection		\$450
Move + utilities		\$1,200

*Earnest money isn't extra — it's applied toward your down payment and closing at the finish line.

THE NUMBER THAT MATTERS

Two of the biggest first-home myths: that you need 20% down, and that you need perfect credit. Neither is true. Plenty of buyers get in for far less — and we can often get the seller to help with closing costs, too.

Section 03

Mortgages made simple

Four main doors into a home loan. You only need to walk through one. Here's who each is built for — in plain English.

Conventional

MOST COMMON

The standard loan, not backed by a government program. Can go as low as 3% down. Strong credit gets you the best rates, and once you hit 20% equity, the extra insurance (PMI) falls off.

BEST FOR Buyers with decent credit and a little saved up who want flexibility and a clear path to dropping PMI.

FHA

FIRST-TIMER FRIENDLY

Government-backed and forgiving — lower credit scores and as little as 3.5% down can work. The trade-off is mortgage insurance that tends to stick around longer.

BEST FOR First-time buyers who are still building credit or savings and want the most accessible door in.

VA

EARNED IT

For veterans, active duty, and many surviving spouses. Zero down, no monthly mortgage insurance, and competitive rates. As a vet myself, this one's personal — if you've served, let's make sure you use it.

BEST FOR Anyone eligible through military service. Full stop — it's one of the best loans out there.

USDA

ZERO DOWN

Zero-down loans for homes in eligible rural and semi-rural areas — and a surprising number of spots just outside Wichita qualify. Income limits apply.

BEST FOR Buyers open to the edges of the metro who want in with little cash up front.

DECODER

The words that scare people

Interest rate

The rent you pay on the bank's money. A small difference adds up over 30 years — think of it like a faucet drip: tiny per second, a flood per year.

Credit score

Your financial reputation as a number. Like a batting average for paying people back. Higher score, better rate. You can move it before you buy.

Debt-to-income (DTI)

How much of your monthly income already goes to debt. Lenders want room left over. Pay down a card and you give yourself breathing room.

Escrow

A neutral middle-man holding money until everyone does their part — like a referee holding the bet. Also the account that spreads taxes & insurance across the year.

PMI

Private Mortgage Insurance — a fee when you put down less than 20%. It protects the lender, not you, and on most loans it goes away as you build equity.

Pre-approval

A lender's written "here's what we'll lend you." It's the difference between window shopping and walking in ready to buy.

You don't need to memorize any of this. You need someone who'll explain it the night before you sign — and mean it.

MY HONEST TAKE

The "best" loan isn't a trophy — it's the one that fits your life, your cash, and your timeline. We figure that out together with my lender, and there's no cost to ask the question.

Section 04

The Wichita neighborhood guide

Where you live shapes your day more than the house itself. Here's how I'd describe each area to a friend over coffee — the honest version. *Price ranges are general ballparks; text me for what's actually moving today.*

PHOTO · EAST WICHITA

East Wichita

Established, leafy, walkable in pockets

The classic "settled" side of town — College Hill charm, mature trees, and homes with character. Great restaurants and coffee within reach. You pay a bit more for the location and the bones.

PRICE

Mid \$200s–\$500s+

COMMUTE

Central, easy

SCHOOLS

Wichita USD 259

FITS

Character-seekers

PHOTO · WEST WICHITA

West Wichita

Newer, roomier, family-built

Where a lot of the newer building has happened. Bigger lots, modern floor plans, and quick access to shopping. Popular with young families who want square footage for the money.

PRICE

Low \$200s–\$400s

COMMUTE

15–20 min to core

SCHOOLS

USD 259 / Maize

FITS

New-build lovers

PHOTO · DERBY

Derby

Suburban, schools-first, growing fast

Southeast of town and consistently popular for its well-regarded school district. A true family suburb with parks, sports, and a small-town feel that's still close to the city.

PRICE

Low \$200s–\$400s

COMMUTE

15–25 min

SCHOOLS

Derby USD 260

FITS

Families

PHOTO · ANDOVER

Andover

Upscale, polished, top-rated

Just east in Butler County, known for strong schools and newer, higher-end neighborhoods. A favorite for buyers who want a step up and don't mind a slightly longer drive in.

PRICE

Mid \$200s–\$600s+

COMMUTE

20–30 min

SCHOOLS

Andover USD 385

FITS

Move-up buyers

PHOTO · MAIZE

Maize

Northwest, new growth, great schools

One of the metro's fastest-growing pockets, with a highly rated district and a lot of newer construction. Quiet, planned, and family-heavy without feeling far from anything.

PRICE

Low \$200s–\$450s

COMMUTE

15–25 min

SCHOOLS

Maize USD 266

FITS

Growing families

PHOTO · GODDARD

Goddard

Small-town feel, big-time schools

West of the metro and booming. You get a genuine small-town atmosphere with a strong district and new neighborhoods, while still being a manageable drive to the west-side shopping and jobs.

PRICE**Low \$200s–\$450s****COMMUTE****20–30 min****SCHOOLS****Goddard USD 265****FITS****Space-seekers**

PHOTO · BEL AIRE

Bel Aire

Quiet, tidy, northeast newer builds

A calm residential city tucked in the northeast metro. Newer subdivisions, low-key vibe, and an easy shot to east-side amenities. Good middle ground for buyers who want new without the far drive.

PRICE**Mid \$200s–\$450s****COMMUTE****15–20 min****SCHOOLS****USD 259 / Circle****FITS****Quiet-seekers**

PHOTO · PARK CITY

Park City

Value, north side, room to start

North of Wichita with some of the more approachable price points in the metro — a solid landing spot for first buyers who want to own rather than rent and keep the payment sensible.

PRICE**High \$100s–\$300s****COMMUTE****15–20 min****SCHOOLS****USD 259 / Valley Center****FITS****First buyers**

Section 05

My personal home tour checklist

Print this page and bring it to every showing. It won't replace a real inspection — but it'll help you spot the expensive stuff early and keep ten houses from blurring into one. Jot a quick note next to anything that gives you pause.

Exterior

- ☐ Siding/brick straight, no major cracks
- ☐ Grading slopes away from the house
- ☐ Gutters & downspouts intact
- ☐ Driveway/walkways not heaving

Roof

- ☐ Shingles flat, not curling or missing
- ☐ Ask the age — Kansas hail is brutal
- ☐ No sagging in the rooflines

Foundation

- ☐ Walls plumb, no stair-step cracks
- ☐ Basement dry, no musty smell
- ☐ Floors feel level (drop a marble)

HVAC

- ☐ Furnace & A/C age (10–15 yr life)
- ☐ It actually turns on & runs quiet
- ☐ Even temps room to room

Windows

- ☐ Open & close smoothly
- ☐ No fog between double panes
- ☐ No rot on sills/frames

Water heater

- ☐ Check the age sticker (8–12 yr)
- ☐ No rust or pooling at the base
- ☐ Size fits the household

Electrical

- ☐ Panel labeled & not too old
- ☐ Outlets & switches all work
- ☐ GFCI in kitchen/baths

Neighborhood

- ☐ Drive it at night & rush hour
- ☐ Neighbors' yards & upkeep
- ☐ Noise: trains, traffic, flight paths

Layout

- ☐ Flow works for your daily life
- ☐ Enough storage & closets
- ☐ Your furniture actually fits

Resale potential

- ☐ Would the next buyer want it too?
- ☐ No weird/unfixable deal-breakers
- ☐ Lot & location hold value

Section 06

Things nobody tells first-time buyers

The stuff that doesn't fit in a brochure but absolutely should. Read this twice.

01 Don't max out your budget

Just because the bank says you *can* spend it doesn't mean your life should. Leave room for a life — dinners out, a vacation, the surprise vet bill. A house that owns you isn't a win.

02 Don't buy anything big before closing

No new truck, no furniture on credit, no opening cards. I've watched it tank loans days before the finish line. Stay financially boring until you have the keys.

03 Budget for maintenance

A house is a living thing. A rough rule: set aside about 1% of the home's value a year for upkeep. Something always needs attention — that's ownership, not bad luck.

04 Never skip the inspection

Even in a hot market, even on a house that looks perfect. A few hundred dollars now can save you five figures later. This is the hill I will die on.

05 Every house has flaws

There's no perfect home — there's the right home with a list you can live with. Chasing perfect is how good buyers lose great houses.

06 Closing is stressful for everyone

The last week always feels chaotic — last-minute documents, nerves, a hiccup or two. It's normal. It's not a sign anything's wrong. Breathe. I've done this many times; you've got a guide.

Section 07

Local resources I trust

You don't buy a house alone — you buy it with a team. These are the people I personally vouch for, filled in with their real details so you've got my whole bench in one place.

PREFERRED LENDER

NAME _____
COMPANY _____
PHONE _____
EMAIL _____
WEBSITE _____
NOTES _____

HOME INSPECTOR

NAME _____
COMPANY _____
PHONE _____
EMAIL _____
WEBSITE _____
NOTES _____

INSURANCE AGENT

NAME _____
COMPANY _____
PHONE _____
EMAIL _____
WEBSITE _____
NOTES _____

TITLE COMPANY

NAME _____
COMPANY _____
PHONE _____
EMAIL _____
WEBSITE _____
NOTES _____

AFTER YOU MOVE IN

The trades worth keeping on speed dial

The day something breaks, you don't want to be reading reviews. Here's my short list of reliable hands. (Filling in as I confirm each one for you.)

CONTRACTOR

NAME _____

PHONE _____

NOTES _____

HVAC COMPANY

NAME _____

PHONE _____

NOTES _____

PLUMBER

NAME _____

PHONE _____

NOTES _____

ELECTRICIAN

NAME _____

PHONE _____

NOTES _____

HANDYMAN

NAME _____

PHONE _____

NOTES _____

CLEANING SERVICE

NAME _____

PHONE _____

NOTES _____

WHY THIS MATTERS

A good agent's real value shows up after the sale. Anyone can unlock a door. The people in your corner when the furnace quits in January — that's the difference. This list is yours to keep.

A QUICK WORD ON REFERRALS

I don't get kickbacks for sending you to these folks — they're here because they do good work and treat my people right. If one ever lets you down, I want to hear about it.

Section 08

Exclusive buyer perks

Working with me comes with a few extras I line up for my buyers around Wichita. These get updated as new partnerships come together — here's where they'll live.

Vendor discounts

Negotiated rates with local pros — movers, cleaners, handymen — for GVonFlue buyers.

ADD CURRENT OFFER HERE

Local partnerships

Perks from Wichita businesses I trust, for new homeowners settling in.

ADD CURRENT PARTNER HERE

Move-in offers

A little something to make the first week easier — details rotate seasonally.

ADD CURRENT OFFER HERE

Utility setup resources

A done-for-you list of who to call to get power, water, gas, and internet on before day one.

ADD CURRENT RESOURCE HERE

Section 09

Moving day survival guide

The keys are yours. Now let's get you in without losing your mind. Here's the playbook.

The timeline

- **4 WEEKS OUT**
Book movers or the truck. Start using up the freezer & pantry.
- **2 WEEKS OUT**
Schedule utility transfers. File your change of address.
- **1 WEEK OUT**
Pack room by room, label by room. Set aside a "first night" box.
- **MOVE DAY**
Change the locks first thing. Confirm utilities are on. Photograph the empty house.
- **WEEK ONE**
Locate the water shutoff & breaker panel. Test smoke detectors. Meet a neighbor.

Packing tips

- ☐ Label boxes by **room**, not contents
- ☐ Heavy items in small boxes (books!)
- ☐ Photograph cord setups before unplugging
- ☐ Pack a "Day One" box: meds, chargers, toilet paper, coffee, snacks, basic tools

Utility transfer list

- ☐ Electric (Evergy)
- ☐ Gas (Kansas Gas Service)
- ☐ Water & sewer (City of Wichita / your city)
- ☐ Trash & recycling
- ☐ Internet & cable
- ☐ Home security (if any)

Change-of-address list

- ☐ USPS mail forwarding (do this first)
- ☐ Driver's license & vehicle registration
- ☐ Bank, credit cards, insurance
- ☐ Employer & payroll / HR
- ☐ Subscriptions & deliveries
- ☐ Doctor, dentist, vet, pharmacy
- ☐ Voter registration

NO PITCH, JUST HONEST

Why work with me

I'm not going to give you the "award-winning, top-producing" speech. Here's the real version of what working together actually looks like.

→ What you can expect

Straight answers, fast. If a house is a bad idea, I'll tell you — even if it means we keep looking. I'd rather lose a sale than watch you buy a headache.

→ How I communicate

Like a normal human. Text me, call me, send me a listing at midnight. No jargon, no runaround, no disappearing once there's a contract.

→ My approach

I came up as a mechanic and fabricator before real estate, so I look at houses like systems — bones, not just the paint. That eye protects your money.

→ My commitment to education

You just read 20 pages of it. I'd rather you understand the decision than just trust me on it. Informed buyers make confident ones.

Consistency beats charm. I'd rather earn your trust by showing up than talk you into anything.

Here's the thing — I'm not chasing transactions. I'm building relationships in a city I'm planted in. The first home you buy with me isn't the last conversation we have; it's the start of being your guy for the long haul. When you're ready, I'll be here. And when your buddy's ready, send him my way too.

YOUR NEXT MOVE

The Wichita Homebuyer *Game Plan*

You've got the map. The only thing left is a plan built around *your* budget, your timeline, and your goals — not a generic checklist.

QR CODE
PLACEHOLDER

Want personalized advice *before* you start looking?

Text the word HOME to 901-335-3905

I'll send you my custom buyer roadmap built around your situation — what you can afford, what to do first, and the smartest path in. No pressure, no obligation. Just a real plan.

01

Text me HOME

Takes ten seconds. You'll hear back from me, not a robot.

02

Quick conversation

We talk budget, timeline, and what matters to you. Zero pressure.

03

Your custom roadmap

I send back a clear plan for your exact situation. Then you decide.

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